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[00:09:56] Good morning to everybody. Welcome to the business meeting of the Virginia Board of Education. We'll begin with a moment of silence, followed by the Pledge of Allegiance.

[00:10:38] Okay, before we get into the real agenda, we have a few housekeeping things. First, under our bylaws, we are allowed to participate electronically in meetings, as might be obvious, Ms. Holton is participating via electronic means due to a personal family matter.

[00:10:59] Again, the bylaws require that that be approved. I have approved her electronic participation in today's meeting from Casanova, New York. So welcome, Ann, and thank you for joining us. Dr. Anderson and Mr. Swan are not able to join us. members of the board had an opportunity to review the minutes from the September 22 and 23 meetings of the board. If so, can I have a motion either to adopt them or to amend them?

[00:11:28] President Gecker, I move that the minutes from the September 22, 23, 2020-21 meetings be approved as presented. Thank you. Is there a second? Second. Thank you, Dr. Davis-Vaught. All in favor, signify by saying aye. Aye.

[00:11:43] Any opposed? Carries. - All right, you know, it's been a long season with COVID and everything, and it's kind of nice to be back in person for actual recognitions and awards.

[00:12:01] A pretty exciting morning for us. First, we will do the recognition of the 2021 Presidential Award for Excellence in Mathematics and Science Teaching state finalists, Dr. Davis Vaught.

[00:12:30] - Good morning, everyone. The Board of Education is pleased to recognize five secondary mathematics and science teachers as the 2021 state-level finalists for the Presidential Awards for Excellence in Mathematics and Science Teaching.

[00:12:49] The Presidential Awards and Mathematics, excuse me, the Presidential Awards for Excellence in Mathematics and Science Award Program was established in 1983 by the White House and is administered by the National Science Foundation on behalf of the White House Office of Science and Technology.

[00:13:07] The program identifies outstanding science, mathematics, computer science, and engineering teachers in each state and the four United States jurisdictions. One year, the award goes to an outstanding kindergarten through sixth grade teacher and the next year to an outstanding teacher in grades seven through 12.

[00:13:25] The Presidential Awards for Excellence in Mathematics and Science awardees serve as models for their colleagues and our leaders in the improvement of STEM education. We are honored to be able to recognize the following teachers as the 2021 state-level finalists for the Commonwealth of Virginia.

[00:13:45] Science finalists are Raymond Cotter. Raymond Cotter is an engineering teacher at William Fleming High School in Roanoke, Virginia. Raymond encourages a growth mindset that allows opportunities for students to critically think about the engineering process as they collaborate to complete relevant long-term projects that require both the application of STEM disciplines as well as all facets of project management. His involvement in both the school and in his community has allowed hundreds of students to access and experience real-world engineering

[00:14:19] resources, technologies, and people. Stephanie Harry is a chemistry teacher at Tabb High School in Yorktown, Virginia. Stephanie's passion for chemistry has led her to be successful in both her classroom and as well as supporting other other science teachers in the division, the state, and the nation. She holds herself and her students to high standards and strives to meet the needs of her students both in the virtual and traditional classroom environments. Her

[00:14:59] leadership extends beyond the classroom as she advocates for quality, rigorous science instruction. Thank you very much. Mathematics finalists. Yvette Lee. Is she with us? Yvette Lee is a computer science teacher at John Randolph Tucker High School in Henrico County, Yvette embodies extensive knowledge, drive, and commitment to the profession and to her students. She is always seeking ways

[00:15:34] to enhance instruction. She searches out opportunities within as well as beyond her school to ensure that her students and the student body as a whole are prepared for the future. She has played a major role in increasing enrollment in computer science by encouraging students, especially females, to participate in computer science courses and events. She facilitates many of these opportunities herself as a way to ensure that her students take on leadership roles. Yvette values and encourages student understanding of cultural diversity. She founded and sponsors the East Asian Culture Club, which is open to all

[00:16:13] students interested in learning more about this culture. This club joined by diverse clubs on campus to host an international festival for the student body and the community. Melinda LeBeau. Melinda LeBeau teaches geometry and algebra 2 at Green Run Collegiate and Virginia Beach Schools. Melinda's strong content and pedagogical knowledge supports her ability to meet the needs of each of her students. Her vast experiences as an elementary teacher, a high school teacher, and an elementary math specialist have empowered

[00:16:52] her to support student learning through the effective use of a variety of instructional methods and strategies. She has a passion for developing project-based learning experiences that bring together multiple disciplines and allow students to engage in authentic learning.

[00:17:10] If you get the chance, be sure to ask Melinda about her mini golf course project. Geraldine Mascoloni. Geraldine Mascoloni is a mathematics teacher at the Arlington Career Center Arlington County Public Schools. Geraldine exemplifies the tenets of lifelong learning and has an innate curiosity to dig deeper through research and practice for what is relevant in the instruction of mathematics. She understands that students who may begin the school year with limited

[00:17:47] formal education have the capacity to learn complex mathematical relationships when equipped with the tools to do so. She has a gift for knowing how to leverage the language of mathematics to help English language learners unlock the big ideas in mathematics.

[00:18:05] In addition, Geraldine is a leader in creating a culture of teacher-to-teacher learning within her school and at the state level. She collaborated most recently with colleagues to provide job-embedded professional development on research-based second language instructional strategies.

[00:18:21] As a result, teachers see the value of learning through their own observations, reflection, and shared practices. The National Science Foundation oversees the selection of the state level awardees for the White House. We anxiously await hearing who among these great educators will be recognized as the 2021 state awardee for the Commonwealth. Ladies and gentlemen, board members, Dr. Lane, please join me in congratulating these fine educators.

[00:18:53] At this time, I would like to ask Raymond, Stephanie, and Melinda to join me at the podium to receive their certificate of recognition i'd also like to mention that yvette and jeraldine were not able to join us today due to staffing struggles inherent in many of our locations thank you very much if you'll please join us for a photo

[00:19:51] i think that's the way we do it congratulations so i was going to say this mini golf thing a golf course based on artwork and um yeah geometry still scale and all that wow that's great figure all that out they had designed it they're about to put where they're going to make it we're going to have a big gold golf course on our campus wow wow yeah that's right

[00:20:31] right here are we are we going to drop our masks and take off your business

[00:21:02] Okay, so let's do it with masks on. That's right.

[00:21:30] That's right. You all have a wonderful afternoon. All the best. Please let us know. Well, of course, we'll know how it all turns out. Congratulations. Congratulations.

[00:21:53] Now I'd like to turn the podium over to Dr. Mann to introduce the resolution of recognition to commemorate November 2021 as family engagement and education month, Dr. Mann.

[00:22:19] Good morning. Thank you so much, President Gecker, Dr. Lane and members of the board. This morning, the board is honored to proclaim November 2021 as family engagement and education month in the Commonwealth. The board often acknowledges the critical role families play in the education of our youth, especially our youngest learners.

[00:22:39] Whether through parents, step parents, siblings, grandparents, adoptive parents, or guardians, the support and active participation of families in our schools supports children's success as they become productive citizens contributing to our communities.

[00:22:55] The board believes that families in schools working together can create meaningful relationships that lead to significant gains in student outcomes. Families provide children's first learning experiences and ensure that learning is a process that extends well beyond the school doors.

[00:23:14] Over 30 years of research clearly indicates that all students achieve at higher levels when the home school connection is strong. Research has shown that when schools and families are engaged in meaningful two-way communication and collaboration, students have more positive attitudes towards school, better attendance, higher achievement, and greater success in enrolling in post-secondary education.

[00:23:41] The board wholeheartedly supports the work of the Virginia Department of Education, our school divisions, organizations such as the Parent Teacher Association, and other partners that develop ideas, resource, and training for stimulating and sustaining parent involvement.

[00:23:59] Family Engagement and Education Month an opportunity to recognize the importance of families and schools being being done throughout the commonwealth to facilitate and actively support student success the virginia board of education and the virginia department of education strongly encourages local school officials to develop plans and policies that enhance family engagement in their children's schools lives and education community with us this morning is tracy lee videoe family engagement specialist

[00:24:38] and gloria dalton videoe parent ombudsman thank you to both tracy and gloria for the work they do to support and guide families on a daily basis and thank you to all of our education partners for their work to strengthen our families our schools and our communities through robust

[00:24:59] parent and family involvement we appreciate all that you do thank you okay thank you all very much thank you for being with us we'll move on to uh public comment speakers will be recognized in the order in which the request was received speakers are asked to limit the remarks to three minutes when your time is up please close your remarks promptly we ask that you please provide

[00:25:34] your name and affiliation uh at the beginning of your remarks uh you may provide copies of your comments copies of your remarks to emily webb director of board relations after you finish speaking uh it is the practice of the board really not to respond to each individual speaker however a member of staff will in fact get back to you uh you know if the comments require it so we'll begin with uh daniel latham good morning good morning how are y'all doing um my name is daniel latham

[00:26:11] i'm from spotsylvania county i'm representing a group called epic or unmasked spotsy students um really i i just want to get some stuff on the record and speak you guys obviously you know school boards have been spoken to all over the state and you guys kind of have an influence on the school board so we wanted to come and direct our comments to you so i'm going to begin and get through this as

quickly as i can uh critical theory or as you're calling its teachings now social emotional learning is a highly damaging force to not only our society and culture but also our children i and many other parents reject any teachings that seek to assign value worth

[00:26:50] merit or capability to a person's skin color. I believe that one of the smartest men to ever speak for equality was Dr. Martin Luther King. We are destroying his dream of judging people on the content of their character by embracing this intersectional racial politic and pushing victimhood on our children. I refuse to accept that a person's worth is defined by their skin color, and it is immoral for you to suggest to our children that they cannot succeed based on their race or that they will succeed based on their race. Our children should be taught to be the best that they can and try their hardest. Success comes from effort, not from pigment.

[00:27:24] Have you seen the society that you are effectuating with your misguided policies? Have you been outside of this bubble in Richmond? Do you not see the conflict and strife brewing because of these teachings? Can you not see the damage that has been done to two generations of children being indoctrinated by these horrible ideas? We have taken a culture of strength, self-reliance, perseverance, and entrepreneurial spirit and have turned it into a world where everyone is offended and crippled by mean words. This is not progress. This is regression. Your focus should be on offering a quality education to all children that prepares them to deal with the realities of the world. You are creating a generation of children who believe the world should and will

[00:28:01] conform to their wants. Instead of focusing on the skills that these children will need, such as reading, which we rank ninth out of 79 developed countries, and mathematics, we rank 31st out of 79 developed countries, and science, we rank 24th. But instead, we are focused on teaching children that they are disadvantaged or advantaged by the color of their skin. And this is a laughable concept on its face, as anyone who has looked at the data honestly will understand that it has little to do with skin color and a lot to do with economic situation. I find it difficult to accept that a group of highly credentialed people such as yourselves do not understand the consequences

[00:28:38] of these decisions. And yet here we are listening to the parents screaming at you to stop. An additional 21,000 parents pulled children from public school years leading into this year, with many more following suit after the September 15th deadline. In closing, I urge you to refocus on education you are providing and less on trying to teach our children morals and core values.

[00:28:58] That is the job of parents and not your place. Half of the state and indeed half of the country do not agree with the values that you espouse. We do not teach our children to be racially motivated and will not accept you trying to force this damaging worldview of hate on our children.

[00:29:14] If you choose to teach your children to be racist, that is your choice, but you do not get to force that on the rest of us. Thank you for your time. Thank you. Emily Klein. Amy Sudbeck.

[00:29:36] Do I go? Yes. I'm here this morning representing thousands of parents throughout the state of Virginia. I do run the group called EPIC, Empowering Parents, Inspiring Children.

[00:29:55] We have been attending many school board meetings in regards to unconstitutional mandates and divisive curriculum. So they have recommended that we come and see you. So school board tells us to come see you. not sure what you're going to tell us to do but here we are critical race theory is 100 being used within our public schools to educate our children the department of education website your website

the deoe.virginia.gov is filled with plenty of information about crt quote all members of society have been socialized to participate in racist systems white people benefit from the racist racist regardless of intentions this is from the author

[00:30:35] robert de angelo's book titled white fragility and this is part of the curriculum that our teachers are required to go through for their licenses. There are many more resources like this on your website. Your CRT training, equity training, social emotional learning, whatever we're calling it right now, is teaching our children how bias and oppression are institutional, structural and systemic.

[00:30:57] Our children are being taught that white people are born with honor and privilege that other Americans are denied. Social science research shows that children from intact families are less likely to spend time in prison or face poverty than children from broken families. I'm a product of a broken family.

[00:31:12] My skin color gave me zero privilege. I grew up in poverty and in an inner city, and here I stand today, successful woman, beautiful family, made lots of strides. And again, nothing to do with my skin color. Our children are also being taught that whites have rigged the system, so the criteria used to measure merit and success in school or the workplace are not objective, but are designed to keep white individuals on top.

[00:31:35] Academic standards are not holding our children back. Our failing public schools are. You're failing our children. Kamala Harris stated that equitable treatment means we all end up in the same place. Equal opportunity doesn't produce equal outcomes. If two people are given the same opportunity, but only one takes advantage of it, they'll naturally have different outcomes.

[00:31:55] It's that simple. The CRT equity training and social emotional learning betrays the idea that the American dream belongs to all of us and everyone should have the same opportunity to pursue success. Stop indoctrinating our children. We know, and you know that we know what's really going on here.

[00:32:11] You can change the name however many times you want. Just know that we the people and we the parents are onto the ever moving target and we're not gonna stop fighting this. A parent has the fundamental right to make decisions concerning the upbringing, education and care of the parent's child. So where do we go from here?

[00:32:26] My copies have my email. I would love to have a dialogue and I really appreciate everyone listening 'cause at our school board meetings, a lot of people are kind of sleeping. So thank you, appreciate it. - Okay, thank you. Amy Dodson.

[00:32:54] - Is it okay if I take this off? - Yes it is. - Good morning, Virginia Department of Education. - My name is Amy Dodson. I'm a Chesterfield County resident with two children in high school. I know my time is limited, so I'm gonna try and be organized and concise.

[00:33:09] There's two matters that I wish to discuss. The first item I wanna discuss is the comprehensive long range unified plan. The edit states in part, comprehensive unified long range school plan shall identify and report student outcomes and shall include actions to improve the performance of all student groups to close achievement gaps.

[00:33:31] I wanna voice my concern that this board will close achievement gaps by lowering the bar so that student groups meet requirements, which will simply hide disparity data so that the data appears equal, but only because the bar was lowered.

[00:33:47] I wanna make sure that performance gaps are addressed not by lowering the bar, but by maintaining high levels of expectations among our students and supporting those student groups who for whatever reason may have been unable to achieve certain performance standards, but not, for example, by eliminating honors programs, advanced diplomas, and class ranks.

[00:34:10] That's simply masking the problem. The second item I wanna discuss is in regard to the mentor teaching program. I'm not a teacher, but my entire family is made up of teachers as well as many of my friends. Every person on this board is extremely well-educated.

[00:34:28] I have no doubt that your intentions are honorable. However, there's only one person on this board is currently a teacher many have never been teachers or were teachers for a short stint decades ago as a stepping stone to becoming a dean or superintendent while you work hard to implement new policies and procedures i don't feel comfortable that this board is aware of the practical applications in the classroom of some of the policies that you put in place teacher retention was a problem long before covet having a teaching mentor is a nice program but i think

[00:35:05] one of the overarching issues directly related to teacher retention is the never-ending mandates issued upon teachers that add unbearable weight to their shoulders. I cannot begin to list all the responsibilities teachers are tasked with in this short time I'm given. Teachers lack the autonomy to make independent decisions in the classrooms to the students they know better than any of us and in the subjects that they are licensed to teach. The implementation of VDOE policies and procedures that directs every nuanced detail in the teaching profession is akin in my mind to the white house making decisions from a dc boardroom to a military

[00:35:43] regiment under fire in a different country on how to take a hill i respectfully request that as new policies are discussed you establish an outreach group with teachers statewide and reflective of a variety of teaching communities and grade levels and accept their input onto the practical applications in their class i thank you all for allowing me this time i appreciate it thank you uh nancy defranco good morning good morning good morning thank you for allowing me

[00:36:22] to speak um i decided at 5 30 last night that i was going to speak today um and i'd like to speak to senate bill 1303 and i really don't even know where to start the bill has taken away any response personal responsibility that anybody in the state government holds because everybody can say it's a law it's an unconstitutional law and with the impending mandating of the vaccine of our children

[00:36:58] in our schools it is it's disgusting sorry we have to protect the children we are going to allow them to be vaccinated with a vaccine that is not approved.

[00:37:14] It is under emergency use authorization. There are no three-year clinical trials tied to any of these vaccines. Sorry. Also, there is no record anywhere in the world of any COVID-19 virus variant having been purified from any patient sample.

[00:37:39] Nowhere. If the legislature's passed a bill saying we should sterilize our children or we should feed them rat poisoning once a month would we all just sit by and allow this to happen and this is going to affect the lower income children whose parents cannot take them out of school to prevent them from being vaccinated i just am appealing to your sense of humanity in protecting the children that is our job as parents grandparents

[00:38:12] educators educators and legislators and nobody is standing up to this horrible horrible law horrible law it's one thing to put a child in a mask it's another to inject their body with poison thank you thank you i will go back is uh emily klein here and uh that covers in the list of people who signed up is there anybody in the audience who would like to speak to the board who did not sign up.

[00:38:48] - You guys are gonna need more chairs next time. - Okay, thank you all. A little closed public comment.

[00:39:05] And we move on to the consent agenda. Items A through D. There are motion either to approve the consent agenda or remove any or all items from the consent agenda. - So moved.

[00:39:20] - Second. - Which way? That was to approve it? - To approve it. - Thank you. Dr. Duran, second Dr. Mann. Any discussion? All in favor signify by saying aye. any opposed no okay that passes thank you all uh item e final review of the 2021 prescriptions to the standards of quality dr sale great good morning president gecker vice president wilson members of the board and dr lane um it is my pleasure to be back in front of you this morning

[00:40:00] to present the final review of the 2021 prescriptions to the standards of quality um and i will start by quickly noting why we're here today um which is that the constitution of Virginia does assign and task the Board of Education with a duty to prescribe the standards of quality, which really serves as a foundation for our public education system, both programmatically and in terms of financial support from the state. The code provides a little bit more specificity for our timeline for review, which does enumerate that we need to provide the review cycle an odd number of years. So here we are in 2020 taking a look at our prescriptions and thinking about how

[00:40:38] to advance what we've done in the past and continue to move the needle forward as you all well know you convened your committee for the review of the standards of quality earlier this summer and much of your discussion was built on the work that happened in 2019 in advance of that review cycle where you reflected on the work that's been done where we've seen progress made and where we may continue to build on that work and advance those prescriptions and the need to maintain and reset markers within those individual prescriptions. And as a result, before you today,

[00:41:14] you have a set of prescription packages or a prescription package with a set of prescriptions that are truly evidence-based and research-oriented, designed to support our Virginia educators and to align our resources with needs, recognizing that we want to ensure all of our learners have equal opportunity and equal ability to thrive. The package includes 11 prescriptions.

[00:41:39] most of which are aligned with the 2019 prescriptions that were reaffirmed in 2020 with some small technical edits to support implementation and clarity and i will note as part of your board package there is a change to the resolution that is before you all today that also includes a recommendation that is outside the standards of quality that discusses the support cap and this recommendation would include a change to appropriation act language that removes the support cap that's been in place since the recession era spending or since proposals for recession era spending flexibility that would ensure that additional

[00:42:18] support is provided to divisions to to fund those additional support positions and with that i will hand it back to president gecker to continue our discussion and move forward with the resolution for the standards of quality should the board wish okay are there any uh you know comments based in particular around yesterday's discussion with regard to the specific items uh i think we had consensus on

everything by the time we were done and i take it the resolution reflects uh you know the consensus of yesterday i think it is an accurate representation of where we landed from

[00:42:58] the committee discussion yesterday and as i noted and and you'll see in the resolution that emily's providing does also reflect that recommendation on the support cap in addition to the support cap recommendation which did come up yesterday with a removal of the support cap recommendation has been done by the board before i'm not aware of anybody wanting to not do it this time but if there is a desire to pull that from the formal resolution please let me know now i don't see

[00:43:29] anybody good uh just take a minute to review this yeah thanks mr geckert dr robertson could um could you call attention to the additional language or the deletion of the language regarding the support cap? I just want to make sure I'm focused on the right reference.

[00:44:09] I believe that is the further resolved language refers. Remember, during the recession, they added the cap. I believe that the section that we're referring to is the further resolve, the last paragraph. Yes, sir. Dr. Robertson, it's that one that begins with be it further resolved at the very end. Thank you. Appreciate it.

[00:44:32] in case everybody had a chance to review this all right uh you know as you all know i consider this to be the most important function of this board uh we slowly but surely are making progress in gaining traction both in the legislature as well as in the mind of the public so uh be happy to entertain a motion to pass this resolution once again prescribing standards of quality for the of the public schools in Virginia, as well as requesting that the support cap be removed.

[00:45:09] - So moved, Mr. President. - Thank you, Dr. Durant, is there a second? - Second. - All in favor, signify by saying aye. - Aye. - Any opposed? That carries, thank you all very much. All right, first review of the proposed stage of the regulatory action to amend the regulations establishing standards for the accreditation of public schools in Virginia.

[00:45:30] Dr. Sale. - Good morning, and I believe I'm actually going to allow Thank you, President Gecker and Dr. Sayle. I am actually representing Dr. Pexton this morning, and so we'll be reading some remarks that she has provided.

[00:45:49] On behalf of the special committee to review the standards of accreditation, I'm pleased on Dr. Pexton's behalf to provide a brief overview today of our work over the past 15 months, and strap in because we've done a lot of work over the last 15 months.

[00:46:05] Our committee's work began in June of 2020. The committee's objective, as you will recall, has always been to conduct a review of the newly implemented accreditation system to assess anticipated positive, negative, as well as unintended consequences of performance indicators.

[00:46:24] Some of the considerations included the board's SOQ and equity work, complexity of the current system and alignment with federal requirements. Since that initial meeting, the committee has received numerous presentations and hosted panel discussions with stakeholders.

[00:46:42] The first few months of the committee's work focused on understanding the complexity of the school accreditation process, the 2017 revisions to the standards of accreditation, and school quality actions and technical assistance as a result of those 2017 changes.

[00:47:00] From there, you will recall the committee began diving into research and best practice. The team from the Education Commission of the states provided an overview of school accountability systems across the country, including examples of school quality indicators from a number of states.

[00:47:17] The VDOE team provided a presentation on the federal accountability requirements under ESSA and Virginia's school accreditation system. The presentation allowed us to dive deeper into how Virginia meets the federal accountability requirements and better understand the differences between our accreditation system and federal accountability. Last fall, the committee hosted panel discussions with stakeholder groups to receive their feedback on the positive, negative, and unintended consequences of the 2017 SOA revisions. We heard from superintendents and principals, the Virginia Education Association,

[00:47:56] Virginia School Board Association, the Virginia PTA, Virginia ASCD, the Virginia School Counselors Association and the accreditation task force. The insight each of those groups provided into school accreditation and policies and practices have that have changed in the field because of those revisions was incredibly helpful for us to hear. In early 2021, the committee received an update on the college career and civic readiness index indicator, an update on growth measures used in school accreditation calculations, and an update on the definition and supports for students with

[00:48:34] limited and/or interrupted formal education. This was an area of particular interest to the committee and one where we are making a specific recommendation for change. In March 2021, the committee was delighted to be joined by members of the African American Superintendent's Advisory Council, who provided a report and recommendations that helped inform the committee's equity work on the SOA revisions.

[00:49:00] In April, the committee learned more about student discipline and disproportionality data along with VDOE's current and future measurement strategy for discipline disproportionality. This was another area of interest for the committee, but one that requires, we believe, more time to collect data before changes can be recommended.

[00:49:20] Since early summer, the committee has been discussing, refining, and prioritizing our recommendations, which are before you today. These recommended revisions are intended to improve the impact and efficacy of the SOA. I will note two specific recommendations that the committee feels strongly about for the board's consideration.

[00:49:42] One, adding language about the appeals process for certain indicators when a school's performance level was determined by students with limited and interrupted formal education. And two, requiring a school's comprehensive long-range unified plan to draw on student group data to identify opportunity and achievement gaps and identify strategies to improve outcomes FOR ALL. BOTH OF THESE RECOMMENDATIONS ADDRESS CONCERNS FROM STAKEHOLDERS AND LOCAL SCHOOL DIVISIONS AND ALIGNS WITH THE BOARD'S PRIORITIES ONE AND THREE FROM OUR COMPREHENSIVE PLAN.

[00:50:19] DR. PEXTON WOULD LIKE TO MAKE -- WELL, I'LL STOP RIGHT THERE, DR. SAIL, I THINK, AND TURN IT TO YOU NOW FOR AN OVERVIEW AND RUN THROUGH OF WHAT WE HAVE BEFORE THE BOARD. SURE. WELL, THANK YOU, DR. WILSON, FOR THAT INTRODUCTION AND FOR THAT ADDITIONAL CONTEXT. and the presentation before you all here today is the culmination of a few different threads of work much of which coming from the board's special committee to the review the

standards of accreditation but also from the internal agency's soa implementation committee so over the last several years since the implementation of the revised standards of accreditation

[00:50:55] a team at the the virginia department of education has been working to field and address questions that have come up and arisen as the the new standards of accreditation have rolled out where we could we provide technical assistance and guidance to support implementation but this work has obviously also flagged for us some additional opportunities to provide clarity in the standards of accreditation and better communicate and build on the board's vision for the standards of accreditation so as dr wilson mentioned um there were a few action items that the special committee took that were outside of regulations, but related to the broader conversation around

[00:51:32] accountability. But because this action does coincide with a formal regulatory motion for the board, this presentation here today will focus on those that did have an impact on standards of accreditation language. I will jump right in. And just as the SOA is divided into individual parts, I will start here with part three, which we know is one of the substantive and meaty parts of our standards of accreditation and addresses a range of expectations, including graduation requirements, assessments, grade promotion, remediation, as well as how we assimilate our transfer students

[00:52:11] into the public education system in Virginia. Because of the size and scale of this particular part, you will see we have a number of notable edits proposed on the screen here for you today to reflect on. And mostly as a reminder, since you all were engaged in that work, I will highlight a few key edits or the ones that I think might be key to revisit, all under this kind of theme and umbrella of making sure that we're supporting our students get to the finish line and complete their graduation requirements.

[00:52:43] So you'll see a number of edits related to the use of performance assessments and relatedly edits to the use and award of our locally awarded verified credits. You will see that we make an amendment to the certificates of program completion, and And this is to align our language with the standards of quality and make sure that divisions are aware of their responsibility to provide these certificates of program completion.

[00:53:06] And making sure that, again, it's divisions are aware of this opportunity and that students who may not have the time or means to complete all diploma graduation requirements still have an opportunity to be recognized with the work that they do while they're with us.

[00:53:21] And then lastly and similarly, we have a few edits related to our transfer students that recognize the kind of practical limitations of when students can take assessments and how to reach verified credit requirements when transferring in at least grades and stages.

[00:53:37] The next section is part four, which outlines our instructional programs for elementary, middle, and high schools. I will note at the bottom there, we do note that this also includes descriptions of standard and verified units of credit. Assuming that this package of changes move forward, we do shift those sections to the earlier part um for ease of readership and use um for folks who want to understand how to get credits and how that relates to the graduation requirement system but for this particular section the two items that i will note here relate to our remedial programs

[00:54:12] and the public education system um first is making sure that our expectations for for remediation diagnosis and remediation for literacy also applies to numeracy so we know both reading and mathematics are important and core skills that we want our students to have and we want to support our

students in making sure that they are achieving what they need to at their grade levels at respective grade levels and then adding clarifying language that remediation work should supplement not supplant classroom instruction while we think that this is practiced in most divisions we certainly want to set the marker and expectation that that should be the case and remediation

[00:54:49] should be provided outside of those core instruction hours in part six which is related to school facilities and safety um we do make a few changes related to lockdown drills and fire drills really just to align with statutory language and make sure that we are consistent across the board and our expectations for these drills but the item most of note here is language related to a comprehensive data security plan and this really just recognizes the ever-growing use of virtual and technological platforms as we think about the exchange of data and service delivery in

[00:55:25] our schools so maintaining security and privacy for our student information is of utmost importance and then lastly in part eight which establishes our accreditation model and talks about school quality and how we support continuous improvement in our schools we made a number of edits as dr wilson noted one of the most notable being related to students with limited and formal interrupted formal education as they relate to the appeals process and while there is an existing appeals process and the standards of accreditation. This does provide clarity on this as a pathway and an

[00:56:05] option for divisions who have seen performance levels singularly impacted by SLIFE students. So it's a way for us to support both SLIFE students and support divisions who are supporting SLIFE students. And then lastly, the last bullet, I won't pause too long on it there because this was still a part of the board's or rather the committee's discussion at its last meeting so i did want to take a few minutes just to pause and reflect on where we landed at our last committee committee meeting related to comprehensive plans um and in that i do want to note that this is again a culmination of a few different threads of discussion that we wanted to make sure that any

[00:56:43] new requirements that we place on divisions are reflecting on data and we're also providing an action item that there's meaningful and tangible goals related to these requirements which is what you see here so we do ask that that again when when divisions are thinking about how to use their data to support and address achievement and opportunity gaps that we are thriving or striving to get to that level one indicator so we are maintaining that high bar and that high standard of quality for all of our students and making sure that that is the goal for for all of our divisions as they

[00:57:17] think about improving and i guess utilizing their data for improvement strategies and per our discussion at the last board meeting we also wanted to continue to reflect on discrepancies even within our level one performance schools and so where achievement gaps and opportunity gaps persist even in the level one indicator the expectation is that the data would continue to move those groups lagging behind to meet their their other colleagues and peers i will quickly note that the still the language does require the board to establish guidelines that will further clarify and expand on what these this component of the comprehensive plans should look like so the

[00:57:57] board will have another opportunity to reflect on exactly what we are asking of schools and divisions in these um and that will come back before the board once we have had an opportunity to to really kind of flesh out what what the content of these plans should look like and then i will open it to questions and discussion for this this item um and will um suggest to the board that this has been

recommended for the board to receive for first review of the regulatory amendment or the proposed phase of the regulatory amendment to the standards of accreditation and will return for the board's

[00:58:32] consideration and final review in november thank you uh any comments dr duran or dr wilson first perhaps thank you um dr sale thank you as always for this um one just a note that i would mention here particularly as it relates to comprehensive plans knowing that there is an opportunity for us to come back to this and flesh out what those guidelines are and reflecting on the uh comments for example that we heard this morning about the um potential implication that as we are thinking

[00:59:11] about unified long-range school plans that somehow we are leaving out this notion of continuing to move all students forward and that it's an either or proposition that we seem to be setting up an either or proposition. And that's not the intent. And I think that as we think about what those guidelines are, how we articulate that intent very clearly will be key and very important.

[00:59:40] And, you know, even sometimes it's even the order of things, right? The order of what we say that can have a huge impact on the understanding of the intent. So I'll just put that out there is something that i think as a board we need to be really thoughtful about dr daron thank you well i'll start with that so i appreciate the revised language because i think it does help by putting the and in there and it also speaks to what we talked about the last meeting the concern about the achievement gap and the level one so thank you for that and your work and making sure that happens and i hope for the public or anyone listening that's a real distinct

[01:00:16] decision we made last time to really be clear that it wasn't just about getting to level one because you could get to level one and then still have some achievement gaps that you would see and we did not want that to be the end all and the goal the goal is that all students are successful and that success would come in closing gaps so i appreciate that one quick question just mostly for the public for clarity and for others to be clear on part eight for this life appeals process can you just talk a little bit more because we've talked quite some time about this and i appreciate all the work we've gotten but i would just like for the record what is that going to look like i I mean, I'm aware of this, but I just want for the record, what is that going to look

[01:00:53] like? What does that mean for divisions and our responsibility as the board when it comes to us? A little bit more just for everyone's clarity, because that is a big change, and it's a change I'm so happy we're making. So I just want to spend a little bit more time putting that into the record for this discussion today. Absolutely. And again, I will just highlight that as we thought about how we might better support our students with limited and interrupted formal education, we did think about that in of a multi-pronged approach um a piece of that being the certificates of program completion recognizing that our students who are joining us late in their their public education career may not be able to complete all of the diploma requirements and again should be recognized

[01:01:31] for the work that they are able to complete while they're with us um and of course division should also receive credit for for providing that support to divisions um additionally there's a data component so as we have a comprehensive and and standard definition of life students we can better understand who the student population is, where they are, and how they're being served.

[01:01:52] And this all, I think, lends itself to the appeals process, which you're inquiring about, Dr. Duran, which leverages and uses existing infrastructure and the standards of accreditation that school

divisions can, or school boards, can bring in front of the board appeals to their performance level indicators based on their ratings and accreditation.

[01:02:14] While there's flexibility in this appeals process already, we understand that it's been understood that how SLIFE students have factored in to the accreditation model and how that translates to viability of appeals hasn't really given it motion or I guess the right avenue for school divisions who are supporting large populations of these students.

[01:02:35] So with school divisions, when they recognize that SLIFE students were singularly responsible for a change in performance level indicators. So would have been level one, had they not a significant population of life students and now we're level two, they would be able to bring that data and information to the board for you all to consider an appeal.

[01:02:54] As part of this appeals process, they would have to demonstrate to us that they are providing support to these students and have certificates of program completion available to these students. So while it is a relief gauge for school divisions, it is also an opportunity to hold them accountable and making sure that they're not shirking their responsibilities to still serve these students in the best way possible.

[01:03:15] And then of course the language does require that the board grant this appeal should the school division indeed bring all of the required information and evidence needed to be considered. - Perfect, thank you. The last part is really what I wanted to be clear on the record because as many of you know, I was wanting to have some more stronger language in around not having an appeal, but the fact that the appeal process where i'm comfortable with leaving it in as an appeal is because the two components you just stated at the end one that allows the board the opportunity to really look deeply to see what supports are in place for students and that's really going to be a critical part of the

[01:03:51] conversation in my mind and requirement for school divisions to show what they're doing to support slide students but then at the end it is a requirement that the appeal does get approved by the board uh if that's in place and so that's the part i think that i'm comfortable with and there's also a time limit that we put in there about how long and they would have to still come back i think it was three years yes is that correct um and i will go back to the language i believe that's correct um but it does require that the board approve the appeals for a certain number of years and then allows the board um to have discretion in those appeal uh appeal processes and again just making sure that divisions are regularly holding themselves accountable to all

[01:04:29] and how they're serving that's an important part as well to have the continuing come back within three years so that the board future boards can make sure that our students are being served i heard a lot of discussion around this issue amongst those of us who talk about this in the educational field and there's many of us who are concerned on the one hand of students not getting the supports things life students kind of being underneath and not getting the attention that they're supposed to and being masked over other data so that's why i think having this is really important in terms of showing what supports are in place but then there's another part about

[01:05:02] school divisions being unfairly having an unfair challenge of having to address their needs by working very hard to support live students but then not being recognized for that which we heard from principals that came during this process so i'm really thankful to everyone for putting their work together and making sure that we can have this substantive change that i think will benefit students first and then

also school divisions simultaneously so thank you thank you any other comments. Dr. Robertson. An observation and a question. Thank you. The observation is we heard

[01:05:39] earlier about the concern regarding whether we hear from the field. I think what we have here in terms of the revisions and then the processes for appeals and what Dr. Duran just said about how we heard from folks before we brought forward these suggestions for recommendations. I think This is very clear evidence of how, indeed, the field has helped direct the work of the board.

[01:06:11] The question I have pertains to part six, and the only reason I'm asking the question, Dr. Sale, is because you've prepared such a crisp exhibit. It's caused me to focus, and it's the second bullet adds language related to security and the requirement to establish a comprehensive data security plan.

[01:06:33] I recognize that the data that schools collect largely represent data that is state-driven. And, of course, it's owned locally and it's also important to the state.

[01:06:54] I'm curious if there's been discussion. I don't know that it's within any of these requirements we're talking about here. Has there been discussion about the requirement of cyber insurance locally to protect state data? Is that a conversation that came up at any point along the way?

[01:07:13] You may not be aware of that from an accreditation perspective, but perhaps from a management perspective, we know that when one has been attacked through a cyber attack, it's very debilitating, shuts things down and exposes sensitive data to the bad actors in a way that can obviously compromise proper requirements.

[01:07:41] I don't know if the notion of cyber insurance is something that's ever come up during these conversations. Thanks for the question. I'll answer that one on behalf of the department. I actually have the language up and I was going to read the second paragraph to you.

[01:07:56] It does not speak specifically to insurance, so that is something that we could look at. Because that has a mandated cost, I need to think a little bit about that one. But the way we wrote it i think reads in a way that almost makes it impossible to implement the plan without insurance and so uh it says the plan shall minimally describe policies for cyber risk management including disaster recovery and resiliency so i don't know how you're going to do recovery without insurance really but incident response and breach notification again the insurance companies help

[01:08:33] with that and then and then the rest of it's more preventative review and audit security awareness training, data retention, data sharing. So in any event, I haven't looked at what the code section says in terms of what's required in the plans at 22.1-20.2. I'll look that up in a minute. But open to your judgment if you want to put a mandate on the board or on the school boards there. But with the cost impact, I think that language at least drives home the need to be very comprehensive. And I think insurance would help with that.

[01:09:09] Thank you, Dr. Lane. That's how I perceived it, too. When I read that paragraph on cyber insurance, it's very, very, very expensive. And I don't know if one day it may behoove the state to take a look at providing certain levels of coverage for all school systems since this is state data, which is being protected. I just raised the question to get the discussion started, not to make any revision to what's before us right now. Thank you.

[01:09:39] And I'll just, one other thought is that it may even be something we come back to standards of quality in a year, and then it would be a state funding requirement that way, so something to think about there. Thank you.

[01:09:58] Anybody else? Yeah. James, you want to talk about this issue or? Thank you. This one actually is an addition to the comment that Dr. Wilson was making in response to one of the comments we received from public comment.

[01:10:16] The public comment suggested that the language may have some school divisions thinking about lowering standards for some students. certainly is not the intent as dr wilson said in fact i think the language that talks about improving the performance of all student groups addresses that but just we really we're we're really trying to be intentional that no one could read this to think anything else so i wrote a sentence for your consideration uh don't you don't have to add it uh because i do think it's clear but just in case the board also fears that anyone could think otherwise here is a sentence you could

[01:10:52] consider, and this is not vetted with policy or legal, but all plans, so I would suggest that you would add this after, I think, what is like the sixth line where it says between student groups, if they exist within that level, then I would add this language, all plans should reflect, I use the word plans twice, so English teacher, Dr. Wilson, I apologize, but I'll think of a tweak here in a second, but all plans should reflect plans to raise student achievement for all students And no plan should seek to achieve their goals by lowering standards for any student.

[01:11:32] That will be something for us to contemplate for next month, but I do think, you know, one of our goals has been to have this written so that nobody can misread it. And you know, as we've seen, perhaps even what we have now isn't quite strong enough.

[01:11:50] So I think we ought to at least consider something else. And thank you, Dr. Lang. I'll use strategies instead of plans in the second plan. Yes, I'll hand this to Ms. Coy, and then we'll have it as an option for you.

[01:12:13] Yes. These are such important issues, and I really appreciate that in the active listening that we are really attending to concerns in ways that truly reflect where the board stands and what the board believes about the importance of ensuring that, indeed, standards are high.

[01:12:31] And we are providing opportunities for all students to succeed. I really appreciate that. In the course of that active listening process, we have a way to reflect our commitment to such beliefs. So thank you for that. Thank you.

[01:12:46] Ms. Holton, did you have a comment or question? Thank you. Yes, on that additional language, I don't frankly think it's necessary, but I don't object to it if others think it helps. I think it's already clear both in this provision and throughout.

[01:13:03] the whole way our standards of accreditation are set up are geared towards pushing improvement and proficiency as you move through the levels but it's a communications document as well and if this helps clarify on the communication side i have no objection i mainly wanted to speak just to uh thank uh dr uh anderson slash pexton even though she's not present for her great leadership on this and and for all the input we've gotten from the public and the great discussions among the committee members i obviously we we heard lots of suggestions that would have gone

[01:13:42] beyond what we're doing now and i think we were right to reserve them for potential future revisions in light of the fact that the current soas are still really in the in their early years so i I think these are helpful tweaks and some that go beyond tweaks, but that we've done the right level of change for now with the understanding that as we gain more experience with the current SOAs, the input we got from the public and others in this round will help serve us in the next round as well.

[01:14:20] Thank you, Dr. Anderson's main message. Great. I would certainly echo that. i'm sorry dr anderson is not here for this particular part of it hopefully next month she'll be back with us uh when the item comes back for final review so the board is happy to accept this one for first review oh absolutely yeah dr anderson yes i'm playing dr anderson now but i'm on that hat um dr anderson wanted me to be certain to express this to everyone she would like to thank the committee members dr francisco duran and dr pamela davis vaught for their time thoughtful

[01:14:58] questioning and energetic discussion over the past 15 months in addition to all other board members who also sat in as part of this committee she would also like to thank all of you for participating in many of those committee meetings finally dr anderson would like to thank dr sale miss shelley loving rider is emily webb and the entire vdoe team for their support of the committee's work it's been her privilege to chair such an important initiative and she's honored to have had the opportunity to advance the board's priorities to ensure all of our children in the commonwealth

[01:15:31] receive a quality education thank you dr anderson slash wilson we appreciate that very much well thank you i've been honored to be a steward of this work and i will see you next time all right we're going to move on to item g uh first review of recommendations for appropriate staffing and funding levels necessary for state operated programs in regional and local detention centers Thank you so much, President Gecker, Vice President Wilson, Board members, and Dr. Lane.

[01:15:58] I'm with you today for two items that you have seen previously. The first is your review of the report on recommendations for appropriate staffing and funding levels necessary for state-operated programs and regional and local detention centers. The 2021 General Assembly session created budget language that required that the Board convene a workgroup to make recommendations on appropriate staffing and funding levels necessary related to state operated programs implementation of appropriate efficiencies in staffing practices any statutory and regulatory changes needed to implement those findings and appropriate programs to redirect any potential savings

[01:16:35] from implementation of the board's findings you may remember that this report was initially presented to you on september 22nd during your work session and we had a robust discussion around the findings of report as well as the next steps related to this work we also reflected the robust engagement undertaken as prescribed by the requirements of the budget legislation of the budget language excuse me with interaction from various stakeholders and their respective organizations it's my pleasure to share the superintendent's recommendation that the board wave first review and approve the report on recommendations for appropriate staffing and funding levels necessary for state operated programs and the regional and local detention

[01:17:12] centers to be transmitted to the General Assembly by November 1st. Chair Greg Musil: Okay. Thank you, Dr. Hollands. Are there any comments? Dr. Robertson? Dr. Robert Robertson: I'd be glad to make a motion. Chair Greg Musil: I see you thinking hard about a comment. Dr. Robert Robertson: Yes.

[01:17:27] Well, I'd be glad to make a motion to waive if that's appropriate at this point. Chair Greg Musil: I think if there are no comments, that that would be appropriate, Dr. Robertson. Thank you. Dr. Robertson: Okay. Chair Greg Musil: Okay. We have a motion and a second to waive first review and adopt.

[01:17:43] All in favor signify by saying aye. Dr. Robert Robertson: Aye. Chair Greg Musil: Any opposed? Okay, great. Item H, Dr. Hollins. Yes, sir. Item H is first review of fast-track regulatory action to conform definitions of traumatic brain injury. You'll remember that previously, as a result of the 2021 special session, the General Assembly enacted Chapter 170 of the Acts of Assembly, which required the Board to amend its definition of traumatic brain injury, which it did at its meeting on September 23rd. We approved an exempt action to the regulations to conform the definition as required by the legislation. However, the legislation left the definition of traumatic

[01:18:19] brain injury or TBI and other sections of the existing regulations untouched. There does not appear to be a reason for the definitions to differ across chapters and further there is not currently a definition of TBI in the section that we're proposing on adding it to today. These changes were beyond the scope of the legislation that required the board to amend the definition and were therefore inappropriate for the exempt action. The item that we bring to you today is simply an attempt to provide clarity consistency and i think really clear communication on the update to this recommendation and to the definition itself and so this will help the field to solidify the information the updates that were made and

[01:18:58] really bring the regulations into conformity with this change the superintendent of public instruction recommends that the board of education wave first review and approve the fast track edition to assure our alignment and regulatory language in the department's guidance okay thank - Thank you, Dr. Holland. Are there any comments on this?

[01:19:15] Is there a motion and a desire to waive first review? - President Gecker, I move that we waive first review and approve the recommendation. - Do we have a motion? Is there a second? - Second. - Thank you, Dr. Davis-Wallett.

[01:19:30] All those in favor, signify by saying aye. - Aye. - Any opposed? That carries. Thank you, Dr. Holland. - Thank you.

[01:19:47] - Morning. - Morning. - We move on to item I, first review of the Board of Education's 2021 annual report conditions and needs of public schools in virginia miss webb good morning president gecker dr wilson members of the board and dr lane i'm pleased to present for first review the board's 2021 annual report on the condition and needs of public schools in virginia as you will note in the boilerplate this report is required by 22.1-18 of the code of virginia this code section outlines the requirements for the report including the current standards of quality information on

[01:20:23] student and parent choice including charter school governor's schools and virtual school options as well as a report on the reports that local school divisions are required to submit to the state or federal government i will note that some of these reports are in the process of being finalized so you do not see them in the appendices of this first draft but they will be included for final review the annual report presents the needs of public education an update on the board's work over the past year and provides an overview of student achievement. Much of the report focuses on the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic on our schools and students and the priorities discussed

[01:21:03] at your September board meeting. The priority sections of the report include information on return to in-person learning, enrollment impacts, staffing challenges, unfinished learning, student mental health, digital equity, and education funding. The report highlights the board's work on the standards of quality, the comprehensive review to the SOA, early childhood care and education, and other key items from the past year. Any changes discussed during yesterday's work session have not been made in this draft, but will be made in advance of the November meeting

[01:21:37] and final review. Additionally, once the text of the report is finalized, an executive summary will be added for your review and approval, along with more information on your accomplishments this fall. I know that we didn't get to dive into the annual report much yesterday, so I'd be happy for us to go through it now with any edits, questions, or feedback that you may have.

[01:22:00] I can make those edits over the course of the next week and provide an additional draft to you in advance your November meeting for feedback. The Superintendent of Public Instruction recommends that the board receive the 2021 annual report for first review. Thank you, Ms. Webb.

[01:22:17] We did have a very brief discussion about this yesterday, and I'm sure that all of you went back to your you know either homes or hotels and sat down and read it again with the with the idea of coming here today to you know discuss it in depth um are there any board members who have comments on you know the draft and you know whether they be stylistic or you know substantive are there areas we'd like to cover that we're not covering you know as i mentioned yesterday

[01:22:55] this document is again one of the few that the board passes as a whole that speaks to our view as a whole of the education system in the commonwealth i'm not seeing anybody jumping at this uh mr president yes miss halton uh emily uh great great job first stab i i i i do have some wording edits but i'll just send them to you uh proposals nothing that i think merits really the

[01:23:31] rises to the level of needing to be discussed by the whole group i'll just send them to you for your consideration separately okay the one thing i would say you know i i appreciate the paragraph where you're looking to thank the board thanking and recognizing tremendous efforts of teachers school leaders board members etc but i i i think we want to certainly also recognize parents and students uh it's been a hard year for everybody um and um and then you do go on specifically and talk about the extra stressors that have been placed on educators and education

[01:24:08] leaders and i think that's entirely appropriate um um um i think it's uh you know we requires a little bit of careful wording there you know unkind words for instance i would delete that reference on page six just because i mean you know frankly that's part of what being on a school board means is hearing things you don't you know you're not necessarily entitled to kind words all the time but hostility and threat is a different order and so i think i would single that out and i might

[01:24:42] i might try to uh narrow it down a little bit because i said you know the vast majority of the public um have been understanding and cooperative and so you know but anyway i'll send you some wording suggestions on what it's worth but my spirit of it would be to include parents and students because obviously they've borne huge burdens here and has um by and large everybody has stepped up to the plate to work to make an almost impossible situation work absolutely happy

[01:25:15] to receive those anybody else dr man yes i also i i indicated yesterday that i'll be sharing some additional comments but in hearing miss colton's comments and just thinking about the broader context

in which we find ourselves situated, I do wonder to what extent is there some acknowledgement of just the realities around what tensions that exist in the context of education today and our

[01:25:50] awareness of that and what that calls for as we think about how we safeguard the importance of not wanting to see children underserved in the context of some of the tensions that are just real, they're present. How do we acknowledge those things? Because they're not likely to simply go away. And I think the worry around acknowledging our awareness of them and where

[01:26:25] their opportunities to address them within the local context, given the authority challenges that exist in how public education is structured in the commonwealth feels important i i realize that that has its pros and cons but at the same time i wonder if we should struggle a bit with that in the context of talking about the conditions uh component of of where education is situated today

[01:27:03] dr wilson yeah i was only going to say dr man i appreciate that very much and i have been thinking some um about kind of going back to this idea of again what we heard earlier today just the feeling that that that our work is in some ways not we we are not conveying perhaps

[01:27:42] or people are not understanding our strong commitment to ensuring even in the conditions that we have our our central focus is on ensuring that all students are meeting their fullest potential and how we do that we talk about the impact of covid but we don't necessarily talk about those other areas that truly are at the center and well it may not we recognize it's happening around us um and you know what is an elegant way to talk about that um as a board

[01:28:20] and at the same time what i also heard earlier today was some i believe misunderstanding of the responsibility or authority of this board compared to the authority of a local school board and what you know so so i think all of that's kind of rolling around in my head so i appreciate your observation so is there a desire then to add to the document a little bit more of the to the current environment you know school board members resigning and social emotional

[01:28:58] trauma i think we may add something you know that flushes out a little more fully our view of the current environment and its impact on the ability to deliver you know an appropriate education for our children and mr gethra i'm sorry so perhaps um a way to get it back is to simply acknowledge but then to reaffirm this board's focus so you know i i am a little hesitant i guess to get too

[01:29:34] far into a cut into commentary um and i'm not so i'm not certain kind of what that might look like but maybe an acknowledgement we know this is happening but our focus is and i don't know and what that looks like you're a better writer than i am on this kind of thing no you're the english teacher but it does seem to me that the you know and it's something that james and i have noted as we've dealt with the schools under mou you know occasionally or more than occasionally the lead the leadership matters and when the leadership you know through the school board

[01:30:10] and through the school superintendent and on down is impacted by external events it does impact the ability to, you know, the schools themselves to function. I mean, I think that's a fair comment to make, you know, in light of where we are. You know, how much we highlight it, I think, is, you know, a different issue. And also, you know, as you began to talk about, you know, sort of the various roles that the bodies play is not well understood. And, you know, sometimes, you know, the separation and the local control facilitates better things. And sometimes the separation and

[01:30:50] local control may, you know, operate against the ability to provide a uniform quality education throughout the state. And, you know, I don't know how far we want to go into that, but, you know, certainly this year reporting on the needs and conditions, it would be fair, I think, to at least make some reference to the difficulties that we have in the school buildings because of the conflict outside the school buildings. Mr. President? Yes. So I wonder if actually would be helpful to put in a little bit more specific specific particularly about school

[01:31:29] boards and school board meetings i mean i think we could acknowledge that you know the public has had strong input about many issues during the pandemic and that's not surprising and we could acknowledge that we regularly hear from the public here at our boards but that our public has been civil and appropriate evidence for instance today we heard from a number of members of the public with contrary views but everybody was polite and appropriate in in how they expressed their opinions but that has not been uniformly the case across the commonwealth at school board meetings

[01:32:07] and i think it may be worth pointing out a handful of those you know school board meetings have been disrupted to the extent that they were not able to continue with the people's business school board members have received threats of physical harm uh you know if i'm right emily that i mean i'm just got newspaper knowledge of that so maybe maybe it's you know we don't want to say anything that we can't that we aren't comfortable with the accuracy of but if it might be worth citing that while the debate has been generally robust and uh and appropriate um there have been instances that

[01:32:44] have been over the line and that we recognize this is a significant you know that school board members are public servants mostly parents just trying to do the right thing in difficult times and it's called to the attention of the general assembly the fact that there have been instances that have been over the line maybe that is worth of an extra paragraph no dr robertson thank you well i i was just going to observe that um emily has done a great job of capturing the staffing

[01:33:20] challenges um certainly around the 10 critical shortage teaching endorsement areas and of course we we sit in a position in which we are most close to the soq and soa but if we wanted to offer some commentary about staffing challenges that we clearly are aware of across the commonwealth there are many other uh challenges that are that are occurring that are not soq soa related

[01:33:53] the bus driver challenge has been an enormous disrupter that's a very good point and there have been other disruptors similar to that that if we want to again demonstrate that we are aware of it it appears to me that we can round out the staffing challenges commentary a bit more yeah and just i'll note on that happy to to add some context to that and include you know a lot of those support staff positions that we know that many divisions are struggling with i will say they

[01:34:29] it will need to be more anecdotal evidence because we won't have that actual data collection until december that i mentioned yesterday but happy to add some anecdotal um and maybe even see if if you know vas has done some kind of informal surveys of superintendents to to better understand you know where those needs are dr doran now go ahead if it's on that topic miss holton i'll defer but mine was slightly connected, but go ahead.

[01:34:57] - Well, mine's following up on Dr. Robertson, so I'll thank you. Just that, yeah, either if there's survey data from superintendents, that would be great to edit in, or even though it's anecdotal, if we could sample a handful, all five representative superintendents around the state to ask for the preview of what their data is gonna show.

[01:35:21] I do think that this will be a big, an important issue for the general assembly and obviously we can update them through other channels when we have the actual data but rather than just being totally anecdotal if we could have some something that would help give a preview called fairfax we've got 17 of the students in the state can fairfax give us a preview of theirs can you get you know roanoke or bristol or handful of localities that would give a variety of pictures of the picture

[01:35:58] maybe i realize that a lot putting a lot of work on somebody not me might be it might well be worth flushing it out more dr duran as we speak to the current conditions and the reality is dr mann opened us up in this conversation i also think it'd be important to speak to what one a little bit of what one of our speakers spoke to today about the impact on our teachers and our principles and the burdens that and yet acknowledge the work that they have done and some way and i don't know the right way on this so someone who's like you said

[01:36:33] mr hector or maybe dr wilson our english folks here but somehow that we can write very clearly and articulate very well what i think we need to do as the state board and speak to the many many many mandates and requirements on teachers and on our schools and how do we in this moment pause to recognize if we really want our students to be successful in what we're in the space that we're in right now how do we find a way to be clear that that's not sustainable over time it's not sustainable to continue to have more and more requirements new initiatives new this new that

[01:37:08] how do we better focus and go deeper on the priorities that we've outlined and listed in a way that's not going to be cumbersome and i don't know the best way to write what i'm saying so just some acknowledgement and clarity and real real putting our putting it down in black and white that we as a state board understand that this is a reality and a challenge for our teachers and our principals and it's not sustainable and what can we do to help them through that i think in 2021 this is we've got to pause people will not be able to continue that's why we said people are resigning people are not able to sustain that physically mentally emotionally

[01:37:45] they're are dealing with their own personal family issues that we went through with covid all of that and then yet we're expecting them to come back and be superstars and just jump right in and then give them more to do we we cannot do that it's not sustainable and so how do we recognize that in a positive way around the work that they're doing not in a negative like oh they cannot do this it's it's not about them it's it's impossible at a certain point and i think 2021 if anything should help us to pause and realize what is the most important part of our work and how and those are the people the people are the important part of what we're doing we

[01:38:21] cannot do any of this without our teachers who are on the ground our principals our school-based leaders that's where all this is going to happen and how do we really speak to that strongly in here i don't know i'm just talking off the top of my head right now but i got to say something about that. Dr. Davis-Bott. Thank you, Dr. Doran. I echo those sentiments exactly, and I thank you for saying that. And Dr. Lane, I believe he was the one that said during this COVID time, the school buildings may have closed, but learning continued. And a lot of teachers put themselves beyond

[01:38:59] superhero roles in order to keep that learning going. Emily, I'll talk to you maybe after I have one question about an edit when we're finished absolutely thank you sir okay anybody else uh i would like to see if the board would agree to tying some of the soqs into the document more closely what i mean by

that is uh we talk about teacher retention and yet we we believe that for example the mentoring program would enhance teacher retention i'm not don't know if perhaps

[01:39:36] So reference as we talk about the problem to sort of the solution proposed through the SOQs might be appropriate. We talk about the PALS data and we have the SOQ for the reading specialist as another example. On the discussion of quality teachers and the achievement gap, we have a recommendation that addresses that, right?

[01:40:00] Potentially a way to have poor jurisdictions hire more experienced teachers. And, you know, we haven't done it in the past. And, you know, I'm not sure how I feel about it, honestly, long term. But I have been thinking that tying the policy that we're promoting to the problems or the issues that we're seeing in schools might be a useful thing as we move forward.

[01:40:28] And, you know, I'm happy to take any feedback on that. I know this is not supposed to be an advocacy document, and so I'm a little bit cautious about it. On the other hand, we do have the reference to the back, to the entire SOQs, so it's not like we don't include them.

[01:40:45] I'm just not sure we're including them in the most impactful way if we want to turn this into a slightly more of an advocacy document on some issues. Any thoughts on that, Dr. Davis-Fox? i agree i think that would be spot on for for what we need to do and and to go with the conversation we just had about how do we how do we put into this document the social emotional needs that the work of the teachers and whatnot i think that would be spot on the resiliency of our teachers coming out of covet is going to depend on how we add to the workplace conditions that's one of the

[01:41:20] the key factors in retaining teachers in our school so i think if we tie the emotional trauma the excessive demands that have been placed on teachers in that manner i think that would be very impactful and emily i'm happy to work with you on doing this this is not like uh miss holton where she says you go do this this one i'll help draft and i'll get the english teacher to uh make sure it looks like english but also i mean we have the you know the el issue comes up i mean

[01:41:56] pretty much everything we address pops up in the issues and needs section of this so okay anybody else on this i don't see did we may i did we have unless you're skimming through but did we have nape test results come a new new round of nape results come out virginia specific this year or was it only the long-term trends and uh i saw the 19 years so is that addressed here i'm not seeing I think, and Dr. Lane can probably correct me, I think 19 is the last year of data that we have, but if something does come out.

[01:42:35] But I don't remember when it, but when did that come out? Did it come out since we last reported, because it did show Virginia still above average, but reverting closer to the average across the board than we would like. What did we report it in the 19 report?

[01:42:51] I think, honestly, Ann, I thought that our math scores were actually higher than average significantly. I thought we were third. Hang on. I think I'm right in remembering that we are still above average, but we are reverting towards the average more than we have previously.

[01:43:14] Maybe it was the one of the math years. I don't remember. But it was, we were, yes, we are still above average, but not as far above average as we have been in the past, if I remember correctly. But if it was, if the 19, well, the 19 results usually get reported sometime in 2021.

[01:43:36] So you did have, we did have a section on NAEP rating scores in the 2019 report. You mean in the 2020 report? No, in the 2019 annual report. oh okay so they came out that early okay i'm confused it is on it starts on page 23. so there's nothing new there i got it definitely do you know of anything new there have been mapping

[01:44:10] studies but no new nape scores listen uh just at some point we ought to check and see you know i did not think we were regressing toward the mean there i thought we were holding our own on everything except eighth grade reading but i need to go back and look at this actual scores again okay any other comments on this yeah james i the only thing i thought of over the evening was um

[01:44:45] whether the board wanted to add even a short paragraph on facilities and maybe the you know since two of you are on the commission and you know we collected some data not necessarily the self-reported data but maybe some of the age of building data might be helpful for folks beyond just the commission but uh i'm out i'm also happy to get you know the facilities team to help put

[01:45:12] together a quick paragraph on that yeah how do people feel about that i like it i'm not certain how much fun feeling well i would think i'm sorry if we're going to talk about the conditions we're going to talk about the environmental that if there are very important substantive thoughts to be shared around physical conditions of buildings given that they also

[01:45:46] impact the experience what it feels like to be there from a learning perspective And I think the General Assembly is going to be thoughtful on this topic over the next year, so you may want to just offer your thoughts on it. Mr. President, I think that the superintendent has, as I've noted in a number of different settings, been very, very effective in presenting the current condition of Virginia's school facilities, both at the Commission on School

[01:46:22] Construction and Modernization and then in other settings. And it would appear to me that the more that we can encapsulate that information in a way which notes that we are aware and on top of it or concerned about it is appropriate okay i think that's fine i think we need to be careful or not to report data that we're not sure of in that regard i mean because we independently have not gone and we are relying on a lot of self-reported data right now i'll try to stick to just some of

[01:46:58] the age data and things that we can validate that's fine all right anybody else if not i think we have a plan then, Emily, and thank you so much for what you're doing here, and the board will accept on first review the annual report. We have the written reports and discussion of current issues. I know Dr. Wilson. Thank you, President Gecker. I just wanted to acknowledge with members of the board that I had the opportunity, the honor, really, to attend the announcement of the

[01:47:33] Virginia Teacher of the Year last week on October 14th, and there also in the audience was Dr. roberson and mr swan it was a wonderful evening and opportunity for me to introduce our eight regional representatives and there are a few things that struck me so among the eight representatives three of them are veterans four of them have backgrounds in science technology and or mathematics and two of them have some experience and expertise around bilingual esl

[01:48:10] education and so i thought that was a really nice mix of expertise around the table and we were around the uh the grounds i should say and um to recognize miss daphne folson from region two as our state's teacher of the year was really really wonderful and in her remarks um she was incredibly excited as

you can imagine but the one thing that she said and that she did she said i told my kids my kiddos that i would call their names and she spoke every one of their names not

[01:48:49] just to call the role but she spoke to them high name that was powerful and i think very quite indicative of the kind of educator that she is she is a teacher in chesapeake public schools um at um portlock elementary i believe so thank you all for the opportunity to represent you all in that moment, and I just wanted to acknowledge what a great evening it was.

[01:49:17] Great. Thank you. Dr. Davis-Faugh. President Gecker, Emily. Recently on October the 10th, there was a publication called the Cardinal News that published an opinion piece titled, Virginia has the ability to fix our crumbling schools.

[01:49:38] Do we have the will? And then the byline says, using a fund originally intended for school construction, Virginia has spent 33 times more on teacher retirements over the past six years than on construction. So I'd like to ask the department for a little more context on this data, if at all possible.

[01:50:05] - Good morning. - Good morning, President Gecker, Dr. Lane, members of the board. My name is Ed Lanz. I'm the director of budget here at the department. Dr. Davis Vaught, we talked a little briefly about this And I wanted to bring to your attention, there was a letter written to the governor as well as the money committees.

[01:50:31] It was published on July 27th, 2021. And it specifically addressed the literary fund and ways that the literary fund or recommendations for the use of literary fund dollars. And I'm not gonna read the report.

[01:50:48] i have forwarded to emily so she can distribute it uh to members of the board but the uh there there are six uh there are six topics uh discussed on the uh in the report uh they indicate a prioritization of loans for construction purposes and um as we all know there's there's uh in chapter 552 there's about 83 million dollars in literary funds that are currently appropriated for teacher retirement uh i think last year it was about 140 million but that's uh that's that was a

[01:51:25] recommendation in the report uh there was uh another recommendation to increase the maximum loan size currently the maximum loan size is seven and a half million dollars one of the recommendations in that in that letter was increase it as high as 25 million maybe to really to to recognize the increase in school construction costs um we there's uh the the loan rate the the the interest rate attached to loans is typically uh it's set by virtue of the local

[01:51:59] composite index uh there's a recommendation here to maybe make an adjustment there um the you know there are certainly there's language recommending the removal of maybe some legacy projects that could be sitting on the the first priority waiting list as late i think as old as november of 2008 i think it goes back the reality of the situation there are a couple other items on here but the reality of the situation is that in in recent times the vpsa pooled bond program has

[01:52:33] been able to provide a more attractive market driven interest rate so school divisions will go on to the first priority waiting list and then transfer over to the pooled bond program that's the reality of what's going on right now and the the letter to the um to the governor and the general assembly uh does offer some recommendations that could make the literary fund a little more attractive for school construction loans thank you thank you sir

[01:53:05] anybody else any comments uh ms holton thanks uh uh i had uh two questions that uh one is on the uh report we received today on the mou i i just like to ask that uh at some future meetings we maybe a uh an oral report from your school improvement staff dr lane is the easiest way to answer my questions but the reports themselves are as i saw them were very process

[01:53:43] oriented and did not give me any overall sense of how the divisions are doing what what what are some accomplishments that have come from the corrective action process what are some of the continuing difficulties either in terms of ultimate student outcomes or even in terms of some of the intermediary things i know we heard for instance this week that petersburg has had some progress on the uh special ed teacher hiring but uh none of that the the reports are so um process oriented that you don't get any feel for what's going well and what's not and what are those uh what are the

[01:54:22] real focus for the next year the recommendation sections for the next year was all basically identical for each group and it was it wasn't it wasn't able to for each division it didn't give me any feel for what are the real next priorities for those divisions so maybe that's just me maybe i can get a one-on-one report or maybe if others are interested we could have the school improvement folks give us a more narrative or maybe we do need to ask that the divisions come before us for a i hate to put more on them since we know how busy they are on so many things right

[01:54:59] now but maybe at some point we want to exercise our prerogative to ask them to come and speak to us in person and i had one other item but maybe i'll pause on that one thank you and we can certainly address that uh you know i'm not going to speak for the department on this i'm a little bit concerned about the concept of you know having them here to discuss you know success because you

[01:55:32] know honestly one of the things you know i've been going to those meetings now for a few years four years i guess of these meetings and you know what the department tries to accomplish is to put in place the structure that allows for success in the schools and you know it's a long process and i don't want folks to feel the pressure of having to come up with sort of short-term accomplishments and what is in fact a long-term process oriented fix which is not to say you know

[01:56:09] i think we shouldn't hear from them but i think we got to be careful how we you know ask for you know accomplishments and things like that uh because honestly well i i hear you i think that makes sense to not hear from them but our board oversight will have a better sense of how i mean the school improvement process and our schools who are at the deepest end of it you know getting the most oversight for the school improvement division i i feel like to exercise our oversight role

[01:56:43] better we you you and dr lane do the individual meetings but it would be wonderful if we could all have a little better sense of how's it going and you know maybe just a report from school improvement on all of them do we feel like the improvement process is working its purpose and and with with some reference to what's going on in individual districts i mean you know as i say we know that i mean the peterford people did appear not too long ago and talked to us about their teacher retention efforts how's that going um i we we talked with some i don't remember when

[01:57:21] we talked in a board meeting or offline about the uh richmond school boards need to adopt a procedures manual for their school board i think they've done it did it meet the requirements etc you know just some sort of highlights of again what's going well what what are some of the ongoing challenges? What are the focus for next year? How is the over, is the school improvement office have the

capacity to be working with this many divisions effectively? I think that's all fine. And, but again, to me, that all speaks to the process we're undergoing, we're going through,

[01:57:56] as opposed to highlighting, you know, short-term accomplishments that may, or, you know, be within the divisions themselves. And I think we can speak to the process and how it, you know, plays out differently in each of the MOU jurisdictions, you know, because there is a difference in receptiveness. There is a difference in where they are along the continuum of, you know, getting the curriculum aligned to the standards, you know, it's, you know, it's clear if you look at Petersburg, how much leadership matters, right? I mean, we're very, I think, I think it's unfair to say very happy with the leadership of the superintendent down in Petersburg and what she's

[01:58:34] doing there and how, you know, James, I don't want to speak for you and I don't want to mention this, but I'll do it anyway, you know, it's, you know, James went down and was very impressed with what's going on in the classroom, which is really a reflection of the process changes that have been made at the superintendent's level and carried on down into the individual schools. I think that's a fair thing to say. And no, I'm not resisting having a report on it at all. I just want to be careful about what we're looking for and what we consider to be success because you know sometimes the short-term goals are governance goals and uh

[01:59:12] you know i think we need to recognize that some of the process changes will not result in you know test score improvements you know for a longer period of time than perhaps any of us would really like to see you know this is a long slow slog through uh how to improve a fairly significant system totally get that but i'm not talking test scores and frankly right now we haven't you know we're we've got a hole essentially for two years worth of test scores anyway or one year of a hole

[01:59:45] and one year of very uh low participation so but but some of the interim measures like how are we doing on our teacher shortages and and recognizing the pandemic may have made all of those more challenging but even just the high level are the divisions cooperating with the state and is that process working as intended and maybe they can do it without calling out individual divisions but you know so and i defer to dr lane if you if you know if this is better done in a one-on-one

[02:00:23] context i'm happy to hear it that way too but i feel like for our oversight role this is some of most important work the department is doing we have made some changes to that system over time and you know that we should be continuing to monitor how it's doing yeah certainly we can put some more information together for you and and and we'll do so uh a couple things i'll i had there was a lot of discussion there and so i won't try to hit on every point uh verbally right now but the um one thing that i would say is that the department does not have the capacity to do

[02:01:00] what we need to do with these school divisions which is why we've asked for additional funding we made a report to you about that in the fall already um well i guess late summer uh and then the the other thing that i would say is i think our divisions would share that every issue across the board is more tenuous than it was pre-pandemic shortages are worse facility conditions are worse teacher morale i mean everything everything is being driven likely by the pandemic which is why why we were really careful not to try to tie outcomes.

[02:01:38] And I know you weren't talking about test scores, but we were really careful not to try to tie outcomes to their progress right now, because we will tie outcomes to their progress, of course, at the end of this year with accreditation. But during those years where the conditions were so different in these

communities, and they were not in person in a lot of our MOU school divisions for a majority of the time, we were careful there.

[02:02:01] But we do have some celebrations, Richmond's graduation rate, a couple other things that we can talk about. I will also say even some of those celebrations were hesitant to celebrate too much because of the flexibility that we provided in the pandemic. And so, but in any event, yes, we'll absolutely provide some more detail.

[02:02:21] - And if I may, just to be clear, when I say that I thought the reports were more process focused, I don't mean that... I actually do think process is important, but what the report gave us was not a lot of information the you know it was maybe so um generic um so for instance yeah i hear you we may not ultimate student outcomes may not be the right thing to be talking about but our and when i hear you say dr lane that we don't have the capacity to do it right my understanding is we don't have

[02:02:57] the capacity to do it right with all the divisions that need it but i i thought we did have the set up where we were giving these mou divisions what they needed and are we feeling like our interventions are working as intended so even though all of those challenges are worse is the ongoing interaction between your staff and the division serving its intended purpose are they helping helping deal with even even when problems are all exacerbated is it a process that's helping

[02:03:36] facilitate the local divisions addressing those those crises or is it you know are there things about the process that suggest that we should be doing something differently or so i hope maybe that helped clarify my question yeah we'll we'll provide some information there and i can explain the context of why additional staff to support the broader school improvement program will open up more capacity for us to support mou school districts but if you look at

[02:04:09] our plan for our most targeted school divisions uh i don't have it memorized but we we get into those school divisions probably with a broad team what leah four or six times a year yeah she's shaking her head yes that's not enough i mean that's not enough wait now we okay we have ramped up our efforts by creating some liaison positions with retired superintendents doing some additional support but if you really wanted to put the framework in place that could help these school divisions turn around and you look at what other states are doing in those type of organizations

[02:04:45] it's vastly more than we're funded to do and maybe that's the message i mainly need to hear and i hear you you've done some reporting to us on that but maybe to think about that in terms of the impact on the actual ongoing loan new processes uh thank you mr gecker and i did have one other question to raise but sure uh and again this one i could just raise one-on-one if i were there but i'll take advantage of this format if i may uh uh test it the crows on our testing now that we are

[02:05:22] doing sol per the latest legislative change in fall and spring i think i'm right this year it's just fall and spring and maybe next year fall middle of the year and spring are we i'm forgetting whether you've told us are we able to now use those fall to spring growth measures in the in our indicators for accreditation.

[02:05:54] Will that happen right away, or is that a future step? Can you ask the specific-- are you asking about how we will rate schools at the end of the year in the accreditation model? How the through assessments will be used.

[02:06:10] OK, yeah, thank you, the new growth assessments. If a student improves from fall to spring on third grade reading, is that going to count as a check mark in the numerator for accreditation this year.

[02:06:27] - Yes, the board gave us authority to do what we're calling a pick best scenario. So we're gonna measure growth fall to spring, and we're gonna measure growth spring to spring. And if students make growth in either one of those analyses, they will be included in the combined rate in a positive way.

[02:06:52] - Thank you for that clarification. - Okay, anybody else? If not, I think that concludes the business of the board. Thank you all for being here and working so hard on this. See you next month.

[02:07:09] - Thank you all. - See you Ms. Holden.



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